



HIRING AI AGENT DEVS

12 shipped to prod.
328 said they had
LangChain
experience.

Swipe →





THE HIRING REALITY



Most candidates haven't shipped.

- LangChain experience is not agent experience
- Demo skills differ from production skills
- Prompt engineers are not agent architects
- 340 applicants, 12 with production deployments





WHAT PRODUCTION LOOKS LIKE



Production differs from demos in 5 ways.

- State management across multi-turn conversations
- Failure mode handling with human escalation
- Latency optimization without accuracy sacrifice
- Audit trail and compliance integration from day one





SKILLS THAT PREDICT SUCCESS



Interview for **production instincts.**

- Ask: describe a production failure and how you fixed it
- Ask: how did you design the human escalation path?
- Ask: how do you handle state for a regulated workflow?
- Ask: show me an audit log from something you shipped





TEAM SHAPE THAT WORKS



The team that ships agent products.

- Senior backend engineer who can read LLM output critically
- ML engineer for prompt design and fine-tuning decisions
- Compliance engineer or architect for regulated deployments
- Domain expert embedded from week one, not week eight





RED FLAGS IN CANDIDATES



Signals of a demo-only background.

- Portfolio is all notebooks and READMEs, no deployed system
- Can't describe a failure mode they designed for
- No mention of human-in-the-loop or escalation logic
- LLM choice is always the latest frontier model





COMPENSATION REALITY



What the market pays in 2026.

- Senior AI agent engineer: \$200K-280K base in US market
- Engineers with production deployments command 30%+ premium
- Compliance-focused AI engineers: scarcity premium applies
- Equity still moves decisions for startup-stage roles





ALTERNATIVES TO HIRING



When you can't hire, **partner instead.**

- Dedicated team model: faster than building from scratch
- Outcome-based engagements: pay for shipped, not hours
- Staff augmentation for specific production skills gaps
- Hybrid: build with partner, then hire to own the stack





CODISTE AI

Need a team that has shipped in prod?

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